Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

February 28, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S05 -- 1999-2001 Model Year F-450 and F-550 Valve stem failures on tires with steel cord sidewalls

Ford is reissuing this letter to revise the end date of the recall and the number of involved vehicles. Ford has learned that the interim containment action that was the original basis for the end date of the recall was not 100% effective. As such, Ford has decided to extend the recall to the date of the permanent actions in the assembly plant.

Summary

- Ford Action -- Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving 1999-2001 model year F-450 and F-550 trucks that are equipped with commercial truck tires that have steel cords in the tire sidewall. These trucks were built from January 1998 through October 2000.

- Number of Vehicles Involved -- Approximately 102,000 vehicles.

- Affect on Vehicle Operation -- Valve stems torn or damaged during assembly (approximately 1%) may leak. On tires with steel cord sidewalls, leaking valve stems could cause sidewall damage and, if not maintained, may result in a sidewall zipper failure. A zipper failure during inflation of a damaged tire could result in injury to someone near the tire.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will inspect the valve stems for leakage, and will replace both the valve stem and the tire if leakage is present.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S05 5d/rjw/ae

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S05 -- 1999-2001 MODEL YEAR F-450/F550 VALVE STEM FAILURES ON TIRES WITH STEEL CORD SIDEWALLS

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

Certain 1999-2001 model year F-450 and F-550 Trucks equipped with tires that have steel cords in the sidewall and built at the Kentucky Truck Plant from September 8, 1997 through October 21, 2000 are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 102,000 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Unknown, but believed to be less than one percent.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

The automated valve stem installation equipment may have over inserted some of the valve stems when installing them into the wheels. This could tear the rubber bulb at the base of the valve stem and result in air loss from the tire. If tire pressure is not regularly maintained, it could also result in operation of the tire at extremely low inflation pressures. Because the subject vehicles are equipped with commercial truck tires that have steel cords in the sidewall, operation at extremely low inflation pressures could result in sidewall zipper failures. These sidewall failures could occur during vehicle operation, or during inflation of the tire. If the zipper failure occurs during inflation, the potential for personal injury exists, particularly if recommended service procedures (such as those specified by OSHA Standard 1910.177) are not followed.

Ford is aware of five minor injuries attributed to sidewall zipper failures during tire inflation on the subject vehicles. Three of the reports allege that valve stem leaks were present.

In addition Ford is aware of 35 field reports, 87 warranty claims and 21 fleet reports of valve stem leakage, and 18 field reports for tire sidewall zipper failures. The tire supplier has reported 231 customer reports of tire sidewall zipper failures and 329 adjustment claims alleging under inflation. There are no reports of accidents or fatalities alleged to have resulted from this condition.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

Ford first became aware of this condition and began investigating it in late September 2000. The initial investigation identified the damage to valve stems from the automated insertion process. Subsequent investigation determined that less than one percent of vehicles were likely to have one valve stem with insertion damage. Information received from the tire supplier indicated that five injuries had been reported due to sidewall zipper failures during tire inflation.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford will notify owners of record of affected vehicles to return vehicles to dealers for inspection of all the tire valve stems for leakage. If leakage is present, the valve stem and the tire will be replaced. Ford currently anticipates that owner notification will occur on or before the week of March 5, 2001.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. Notices to dealers and owners from Ford Customer Service Division will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S05 to this action.